

ALL EYES ON HIM
Bhajan Lal Sharma, Chief Minister, Rajasthan

ANI

The odds are daunting. Though the BJP wrested 115 seats in the assembly election last December, it has been on the back foot in six of the seven constituencies where the bypolls are to be held. In fact, the Congress has secured victories in three of these seats—Dausa, Deoli-Uniara and Ramgarh—twice in a row, while Jhunjhunu has been its bastion for four straight elections. Similarly, Khinvsar is the citadel of Rashtriya Loktantrik Party (RLP) founder Hanuman Beniwal, and Chorasi of Bharat Adivasi Party (BAP) founder Rajkumar Roat. Both have been elected to the Lok Sabha, necessitating the byelections. That leaves only Salumber, represented by three-term BJP legislator Amrit Lal Meena until his demise in August, as a somewhat safe seat for the ruling party. This reality looms over Sharma as he seeks to convert his efforts into electoral success.

What works in his favour is that both the RLP and the BAP, which were part of the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) in the general election, have decided to go solo. On the other hand, the Congress is vying for all seven seats. This division creates a competitive atmosphere that could benefit the BJP, especially in triangular contests. Take Khinvsar, for instance, where the RLP's Kanika Beniwal—wife of Hanuman Beniwal—faces off against the BJP's Rewant Ram Danga and Congress's Ratan Chaudhary. In Chorasi, the BAP candidate, Mahesh Raut, is working to retain control after Rajkumar's departure to Parliament.

For the BJP, these byelections are a crucial opportunity to validate its recent strategy of introducing new faces into the political fray. The party is keen to leverage high-profile endorsements: there's been talk of Prime Minister Narendra Modi potentially laying the foundation stone of the long-stalled Eastern River Canal Project (ERCP) ahead of polling day. This initiative could resonate with voters if framed as a concrete benefit. Yet, concerns about the project linger, which the party is trying its best to dispel.

Internal tensions also simmer within the BJP. The party's decision to field former rebels and family members of dissenting leaders underscores its vulnerability; over the past decade, it has secured only three wins in 16 byelections. This reality has prompted compromises, as seen in Dausa where the BJP has nominated Jagmohan Meena, brother of the 'sulking' cabinet minister Kirodi Lal Meena. The latter had tendered his resignation in June, though it has yet to be accepted. In fact, his nephew Rajendra Meena is also an MLA, so the brother's nomination deepens the image

POLL DYNAMICS

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